

Off the Shelf



Dr Seuss: The Cat in the Hat

It's fun

This side-scrolling arcade game reminds you of your old Nintendo games. It's got characters created by Dr Seuss (of the poem *Green Eggs and Ham* fame), and is inspired from the movie with the same name starring Mike Myers (of *Austin Powers* fame). And it's fun.

The magical Cat decides to pay Conrad and Sally—a couple of really bored kids—a surprise visit. The strange next-door neighbour, Mr Quinn, persuades Conrad to open the Cat's magical box, letting all hell loose. To make matters worse, Quinn's now off to collect the magic and become all-powerful. So the Cat bravely volunteers to set off with the aim of capturing all the magic and bringing Quinn to book.

Since the game is based on a children's book, it's as family-friendly as can be. Bright colours, comic characters, funny one-liners, non-violent action. This might be a 'children's game,' but it'll take all your hand-eye co-ordination and lightning reflexes to master it. In that sense, it's as hardcore as it gets.

The action follows a fairly linear sequence. Several appliances in the house have been mutated by magic. You need to enter one that currently houses Quinn,

fight your way across the level, and chase him out. To achieve this, you have a fabulous umbrella at your disposal. This multi-utility tool can shoot an endless stream of bubbles, capturing all monsters in its path. You can now pick up these entrapped creatures to blast other entities, or blow away obstacles in your path. The umbrella can also help you glide across short distances, act as a shield, and when held upside down, can be used to slam down upon creatures and buttons.

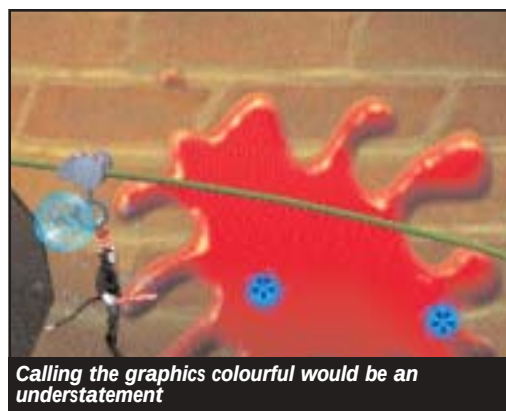
Along the way, you'll need to watch out for spikes, cuckoo clocks, lobsters, Cat-eating plants, steam blowers, hammers, and tons of other hazards. There's such a wide variety of ways you can die, you'll never get tired of it. But it isn't all evil. You can grab cake slices to boost your health, jump onto bubble-exhaust rockets to take you across long distances, and find little hearts to add to your cat lives.

Once you collect all the magic from the level, and chase out Quinn, the mutated area returns to its original self. You might not always get all the magic on your first pass, so you're free to come back whenever you want to have another go. You can go right up to the end, then turn around and go right back to the beginning!

The game isn't a side-scroller all the time. The camera viewpoint rotates around the character, and zooms in and out, depending on the twists and turns the 3D world takes. The world is extremely colourful, but the inability to change resolutions hurts. Often, you aren't able to see what lies a bit ahead of you, and this leads to your doom.



A jumping puzzle you do not want to mess up



Calling the graphics colourful would be an understatement

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Digital Eclipse ■ **Publisher:** Vivendi Universal Games ■ **Distributor:** E-xpress interactive Software Pvt Ltd
Phone: 022-2887017 ■ **E-mail:** anand@e-xpressindia.com ■ **System Requirements:** 600 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, 16 MB 3D card ■ **Price:** Rs 1,299
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Rating: ★★★★★